In general, citizens of the world buy their e-mail and internet services from US companies that cooperate—some more than others— with the NSA. This means that citizens and bodies from other countries are less influential in international markets than their US competitors.

Even the encrypted traffic of global telecommunications networks is not immune to the NSA's enormous power. The advent of computers, including personal computers, the internet, and cell phones, has made the NSA the world's largest spy agency. The NSA can intercept all of the traffic that passes through fiber-optic cables; it can connect to any telephone system or website in the world; it can digitally "rob" any laptop and can plant bugs on smartphones anywhere in the world.

Among Snowden's leaks was the revelation that ahead of President Obama's meeting with UN secretary-general Ban Ki-moon in April 2013, the NSA had eavesdropped on the secretary-general and provided Obama with the talking points he had prepared for their meeting.[6]

The NSA operates surveillance aircraft over territories defined as being "of interest" (Colombia); it maintains surveillance bases aboard US Navy ships near other places of interest (China) and transmits the results via satellite in real time to the organization's headquarters in Fort Meade, Maryland, about thirty kilometers from Washington, D.C. The NSA runs surveillance bases at eighty US embassies and consulates around the world and oversees all financial and banking traffic worldwide. The NSA can organize itself to deal with events around the world on short notice by immediately concentrating and pooling the various resources at its disposal.

The United States has sixteen different intelligence agencies, but at the president's daily intelligence briefing more than half of the information comes from NSA sources. The NSA has an intelligence alliance with services from England, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, called the "Five Eyes." There is a division of labor among them and they share data with each other. Other intelligence alliances are the Nine Eyes, the Fourteen Eyes, and the NATO Special Committee, made up of the heads of the security services of NATO's member countries.

The NSA cooperates with Israel, while at the same time collecting information on Israeli targets.[7]

The NSA is the largest employer of mathematicians in the United States, for the purpose of breaking codes.

The NSA is the biggest employer of hackers.